

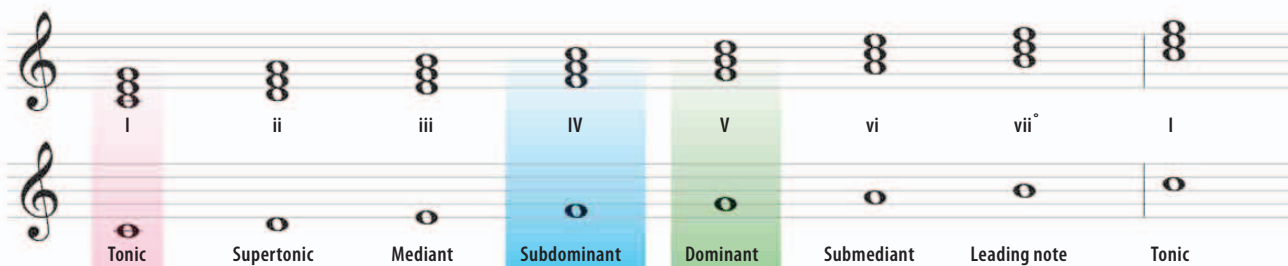
Naming triads

Each triad has a number according to its place in the scale. The number is written in Roman numerals—I is built on the tonic, II is on the second note of the scale, and so on. Major triads are written in capital roman letters (I-II-III), and minor triads are written in lower case (i-ii-iii). Diminished triads are indicated with a superscript circle (vii°).



△ What is the key?

One triad of the same three notes can have different meanings according to the key. So I of A minor (A-C-E) is composed of the same notes as the subdominant of E minor, and the dominant of D minor.



△ Leading note

The seventh note of the scale is known as the leading note because it leads directly into the tonic of the scale, up an octave.

Diminished triads

Diminished triads are separated by intervals of a minor third, or three half steps. They are less stable than perfect triads because the two intervals add up to a dissonant interval, the diminished fifth (known as a tritone) of six half steps.



◁ Diminished triads

Formed by the root, the third note of the scale, and the flattened fifth, a diminished triad is indicated with a + sign. The triad shown here is C dim or C°.

diminished triad = minor third + ♭ fifth

Triad	Root	Minor third	Diminished fifth
C dim (Cm (♭ 5))	C	E♭	G♭
C# dim (C#m (♭ 5))	C#	E	G
D dim (Dm (♭ 5))	D	F	A♭
D# dim (D#m (♭ 5))	D#	F#	A
E dim (Em (♭ 5))	E	G	B♭
F dim (Fm (♭ 5))	F	A♭	C♭ (B)
F# dim (F#m (♭ 5))	F#	A	C
G dim (Gm (♭ 5))	G	B♭	D♭
G# dim (G#m (♭ 5))	G#	B	D
A dim (Am (♭ 5))	A	C	E♭
A# dim (A#m (♭ 5))	A#	C#	E
B dim (Bm (♭ 5))	B	D	F

◁ Triad or chord?

These are simply triads, but sometimes the “dim” sign indicates the addition of a diminished seventh. They are especially common in jazz and popular music.